

Week 9: Grant Takes Command/The Road to Appomattox

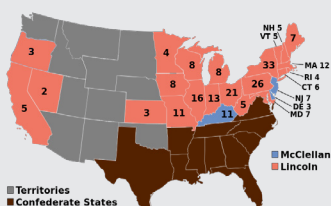
Questions

1. Consider the impact of Grant's command on the War.
2. Based upon your reading assignments, how would you compare the feelings of the Northern and Southern soldiers toward their country as the armies demobilized after the war? What consequences would you say this would have for Reconstruction?
3. Examine Lincoln's leadership in formulating wartime Reconstruction policy. Was his policy a success or a failure in Louisiana, the most important example of early Reconstruction? Be sure and include in your answer the different groups that Lincoln had to contend with, both in the Republican party (or the National Union party as it was called in 1864) and in the South.

Key Terms

- The Overland Campaign
- William T. Sherman
- March Through Georgia
- Special Field Order No. 15
- Election of 1864
- March Through Georgia
- Lee and Grant at Appomattox, April 9, 1865

Results, Election of 1864



Abraham Lincoln (R-IL)

Popular votes: 2,218,388
Electoral votes: 212

George McClellan (D-NJ)

Popular votes: 1,812,807
Electoral votes: 21

Grant Pushes South

For the Union army, the Battle of the Wilderness had been a decided failure. Two days of fighting in the tangled thickets had resulted in some 18,000 Union casualties, almost as many as Hooker had sustained at Chancellorsville and considerably more than Burnside had suffered at Fredericksburg. Lee, by contrast, probably suffered fewer than 12,000 casualties. Both Burnside and Hooker had retreated across the Rappahannock following their battles with Lee, but Grant did not. In one of the most far-reaching decisions of the war, he directed his engineers to take up the pontoon bridges at Germanna Ford on May 7 and issued orders to his corps commanders to march toward Spotsylvania Court House that night. When Union soldiers discovered that Grant was pushing ahead despite his losses, they cheered him. They had finally found a general who would continue to fight Lee until he beat him. In the following excerpt, Grant's aide-de-camp, Colonel Horace Porter, describes this unexpected ovation that took place in the depths of the Wilderness.

"Soon after dark, Generals Grant and Meade, accompanied by their staffs, after having given personal supervision to the starting of the march, rode along the Brock road toward Hancock's headquarters, with the intention of waiting there till Warren's troops should reach that point. While moving close to Hancock's line, there occurred an unexpected demonstration on the part of the troops, which created one of the most memorable scenes of the campaign. Notwithstanding the darkness of the night, the form of the commander was recognized, and word was passed rapidly along that the chief who had led them through the mazes of the Wilderness was again moving forward with his horse's head turned toward Richmond. Troops know but little about what is going on in a large army, except the occurrences which take place in their immediate vicinity; but this night ride of the general-in-chief told plainly the story of success, and gave each man to understand that the cry was to be 'On to Richmond!' Soldiers weary and sleepy after their long battle, with stiffened limbs and smarting wounds, now sprang to their feet, forgetful of their pains, and rushed forward to the roadside. Wild cheers echoed through the forest, and glad shouts of triumph rent the air. Men swung their hats, tossed up their arms, and pressed forward to within touch of their chief, clapping their hands, and speaking to him with the familiarity of comrades. Pine-knots and leaves were set on fire, and lighted the scene with their weird, flickering glare. The night march had become a triumphal procession for the new commander. The demonstration was the emphatic verdict pronounced by the troops upon his first battle in the East. The excitement had been imparted to the horses, which soon became restive, and even the general's large bay, over which he possessed ordinarily such perfect control, became difficult to manage. Instead of being elated by this significant ovation, the general, thoughtful only of the practical question of the success of the movement, said: 'This is most unfortunate. The sound will reach the ears of the enemy, and I fear it may reveal our movement.' By his direction, staff-officers rode forward and urged the men to keep quiet so as not to attract the enemy's attention; but the demonstration did not really cease until the general was out of sight."



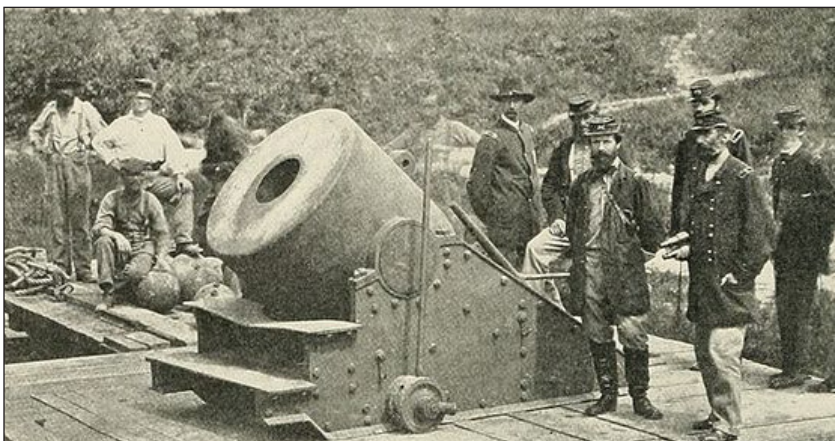
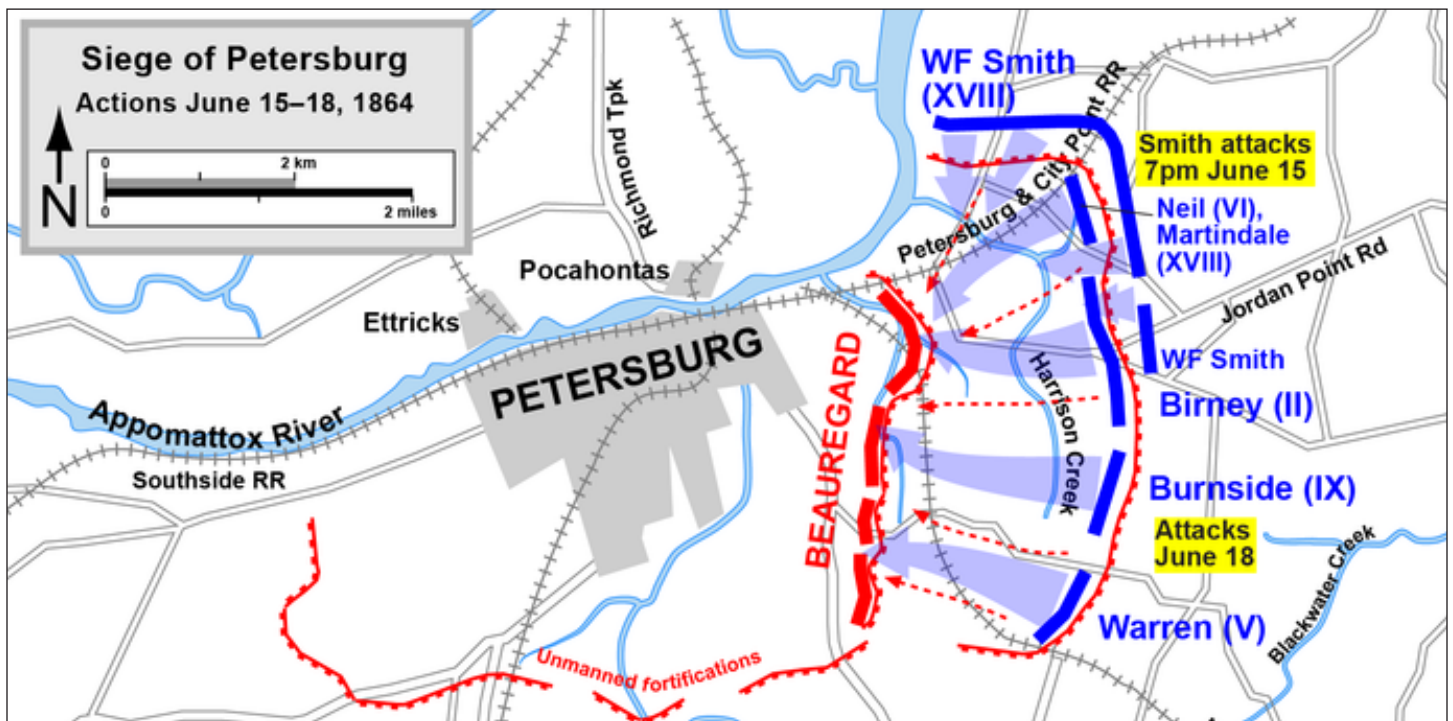
Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant is cheered by his troops on the march to Spotsylvania Court House in May 1864.

As for fighting, it was simply bushwacking on a grand scale, in brush where all formation... was soon lost and where such a thing as consistent line of battle... was impossible.

- Anonymous Union soldier on the 1864 Battle of the Wilderness

It aint no battle, it's a worse riot than Chickamauga! At Chickamauga there was at least a rear, but here there aint neither front nor rear. It's all a damned mess!

- Anonymous Confederate prisoner on the 1864 Battle of the Wilderness



In anticipation of a Union attack, Confederate soldiers worked day and night to construct defenses in the vicinity of Cold Harbor (above). One soldier reported that his brigade, "worked all night with only bayonets, cups, two or three picks, and as many shovels." When the Union did attack on May 31, 1864, it proved disastrous for them—one of their worst losses of the war, and the worst of Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant's career. It also proved to be Robert E. Lee's final major victory of the Civil War. Days after Cold Harbor, Grant would lay siege to Petersburg, Va. (middle) utilizing his vastly superior artillery (including "The Dictator," left). This would set in motion a chain of events that culminated in the fall of Richmond and the surrender of Lee's army.

African Americans at Petersburg

At the beginning of the Civil War, Virginia had a slave population of about 491,000 and a free black population of almost 58,000. About half of Petersburg's 18,266 residents were black, of which 3,164 were free. Petersburg was considered to have the largest number of free blacks of any Southern city at that time. Many of the freedmen prospered here as barbers, blacksmiths, boatmen, draymen, livery stable keepers, and caterers. There were also those who owned considerable property, particularly in the communities of Blandford and Pocahontas.

Serving the Confederacy

When Petersburg became a major supply center for the newly formed Confederacy and its nearby capital in Richmond, both freedmen and slaves were employed in various war functions. More than 850 slaves and free blacks worked for the numerous railroad companies that operated in and out of the city. In the latter part of 1862, when a ten-mile-long defense line was begun around Petersburg, Captain Charles H. Dimmock used both freedmen and slave labor to construct the trenches and batteries. In the many hospitals that sprang up in the city, blacks served as nurses and servants.

Once the siege began in June 1864, African-Americans continued working for the Confederacy. In September 1864, General Lee asked for an additional 2,000 blacks to be added to his labor force. In March 1865, with the serious loss of white manpower in the army, the Southern army called for 40,000 slaves to become an armed force in the Confederacy. A notice in the April 1, 1865, Petersburg Daily Express called for black recruits with the statement, "To the slaves is offered freedom and undisturbed residence at their old homes in the Confederacy after the war. Not the freedom of sufferance, but honorable and self-won by the gallantry and devotion which grateful countrymen will never

cease to remember and reward." It is not known how many responded to this challenge. The war ended before any major contribution could be made.

Serving the Union: U.S. Colored Troops in the Siege of Petersburg

During the war, a total of 186,097 blacks served in the Union army, with the first regiments activated after September 1862. In front of Petersburg, two black divisions numbering about 7,800 men (nineteen regiments) saw action.

In the initial assault upon the city on June 15, 1864, a division of General Edward Hincks attacked the Confederate Dimmock Line. Comprising 3,500 men from the Eighteenth Corps of the Army of the James, which was commanded by General Benjamin F. Butler, Hincks's troops helped capture and secure a section of the Southern defenses from Batteries 7 through 11. In the initial stage of this action, located at Baylor's Farm on the City Point Road, the black troops also captured a gun from Captain Edward Graham's Petersburg Artillery. On the fifteenth, Hincks's Division lost 378 killed and wounded. They acted in a supporting role on the June 18 assault, suffering a loss of 36 men.

The other division of United States Colored Troops to serve at Petersburg was the Fourth Division, Ninth Corps, under General Ambrose E. Burnside and the Army of the Potomac. Four thousand, three hundred strong, these men were involved in one of the most well-known events of the Siege, the Battle of the Crater, fought on July 30, 1864.

For three weeks as a Pennsylvania Regiment dug a tunnel under a Confederate fort to blow it up, the black troops were being trained to lead the assault once the battle commenced. The black troops were chosen because they were

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African-American troops of the Fourth Division at Petersburg, following the Battle of the Crater

A slight tremor of the earth for a second, then the rocking as of an earthquake, and with a tremendous burst which rent the sleeping hills beyond, a vast column of earth and smoke shoots upward to a great height, its dark sides flashing out sparks of fire, hangs poised for a moment in mid-air, and then hurtling downward with a roaring sound showers of stones, broken timbers, and blackened human limbs, subsides the gloomy pall of darkening smoke flushing to an angry crimson as it floats away to meet the morning sun.

- Anonymous Union soldier on the effect of the mine



African-American troops capture a Confederate cannon, in a drawing by an unknown artist



numerically superior, and having been mainly wagon guards up to this point, they had seen little action. With the white troops showing exhaustion after the severe fighting of the campaign from the Wilderness to Petersburg, it was believed the blacks would have a better chance at being successful.

Unfortunately for the black soldiers, the commander of the Army of the Potomac, General George G. Meade, would change Burnside's plan twenty-four hours before the battle. Instead of leading the assault, their division, led by General Edward Ferrero, would now be the last to go in.

Once the explosion took place on the morning of July 30, the three white divisions tried to reach their objective, Cemetery Hill. Stiff Confederate resistance along with a lack of leadership on the Union side, bogged down the Union assault in the area of the Crater. When Ferrero's troops attempted their attack, they ran into a Confederate counterattack led by General William Mahone. As the blacks were forced back into the Crater with Burnside's other troops, stiff hand-to-hand combat now began and the face of battle changed. Some claimed the black troops went into the battle yelling "Remember Fort Pillow," the site of an earlier massacre of black prisoners in Tennessee, while others said "no quarter" was shouted by the blacks. Many of the Confederates were enraged that black troops were being deployed against them, and the fighting became vicious. As a result, many blacks who surrendered were not taken prisoner; the division suffered 209 killed, 697 wounded, and 421 missing or captured, a total of 1,327 or 38 percent of the Ninth Corps loss.

Following the battle, Sergeant Decatur Dorsey of the 39th U.S.C.T. received the Medal of Honor for "rushing forward in advance of his regiment and placing his colors on the Confed-

erate trenches." Three white officers who commanded black troops at the Crater also received medals.

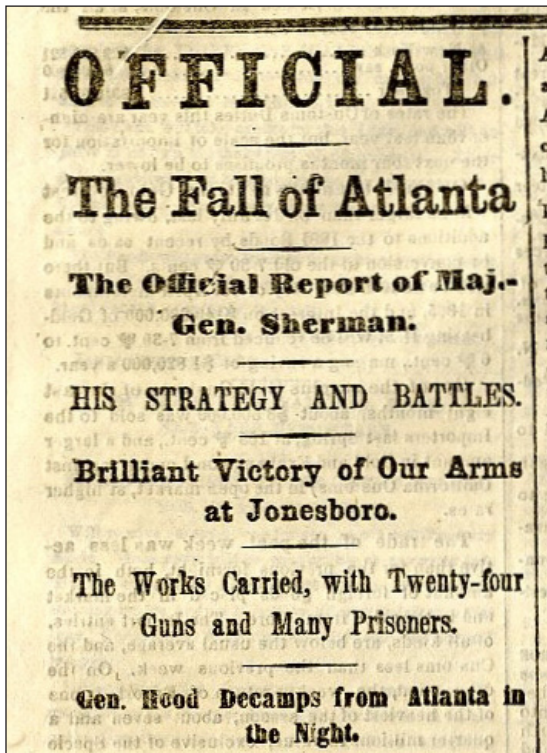
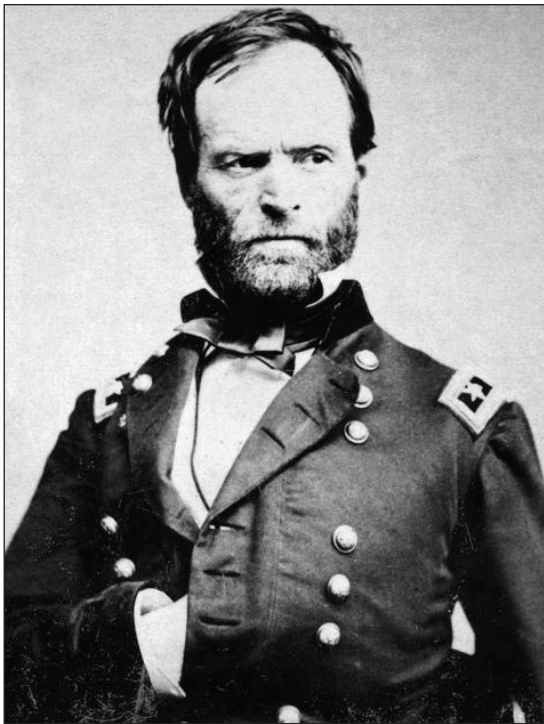
The division captured approximately 300 prisoners and one battle flag during the engagement. In December 1864, all the United States Colored Troops around Petersburg were incorporated into three divisions and became the Twenty-Fifth Corps of the Army of the James. Commanded by General Godfrey Weitzel, it was the largest black force assembled during the war and varied in numbers from 9,000 to 16,000 men.

When Petersburg fell to the Union army on April 3, 1865, some of the Twenty-Fifth Corps marched through the city on their way to Appomattox. A newspaper reporter wrote "A negro regiment passing seems to take special pride and pleasure in maintaining the dignity becoming soldiers, and are neither boisterous nor noisy." These men continued to march with Grant's army and were present at Lee's surrender on April 9, 1865.

African-Americans at City Point

With General Grant's logistical supply base located at City Point (now Hopewell) on the James River, African-Americans served in varying capacities for the Union army. The soldiers acted as sentries, guarding the numerous ships that were docked at the wharves. Some employees of the U.S. Military Railroad Construction Corps were Northern blacks and worked as laborers in building the needed facilities. An observer wrote "legions of negroes were discharging the ships, wheeling dirt, sawing the timber, and driving piles." Many also worked at the Depot Field Hospital, with the women serving as laundresses and in the diet kitchen, the men as cooks. About 160 blacks assisted there.

Sherman's March to the Sea: November 15–December 21, 1864

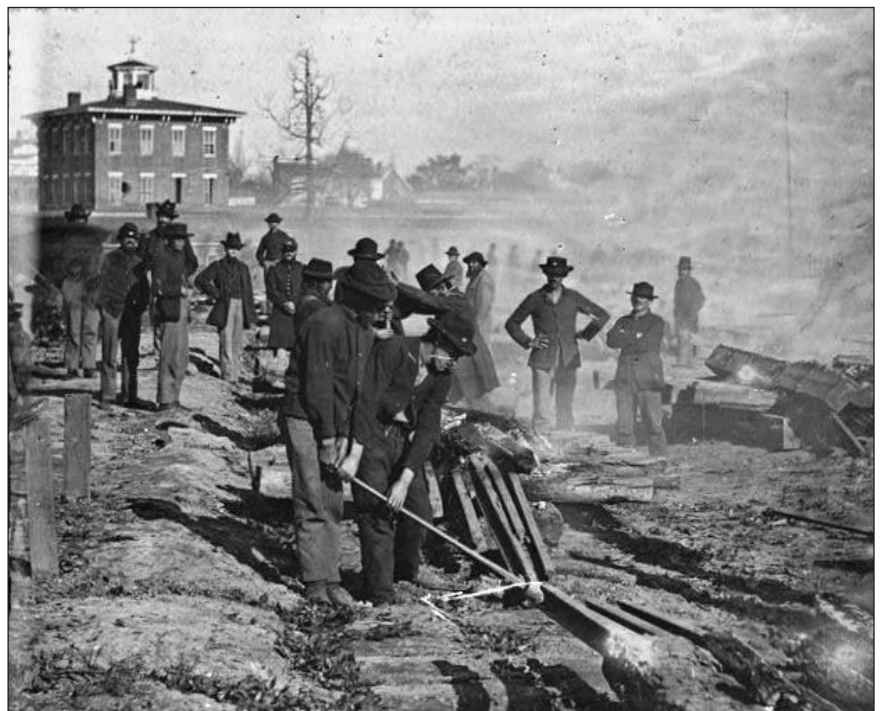
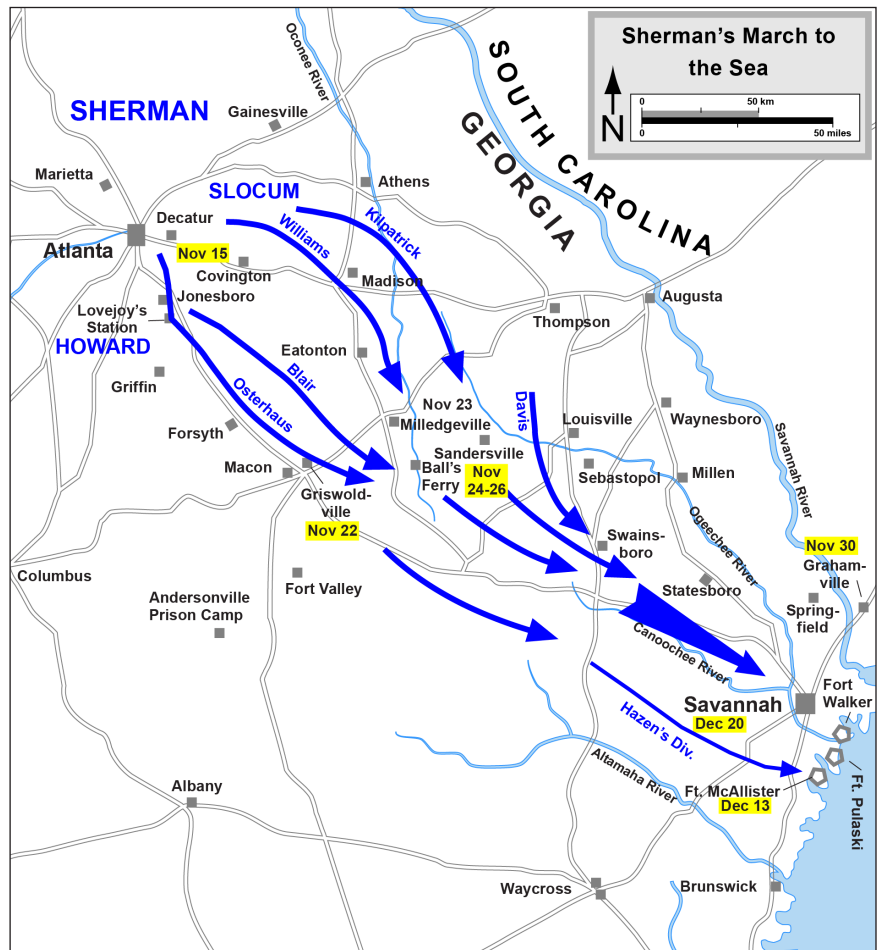


Why don't you go over to South Carolina and serve them this way? They started it.

- Georgia farmer to Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman

The truth is, the whole army is burning with an insatiable desire to wreak vengeance upon South Carolina. I almost tremble at her fate, but feel that she deserves all that seems in store for her.

- Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman



Recognizing the necessity of undermining civilian support for the Confederacy, Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman (top left) vowed in late 1864 to "make Georgia Howl." After capturing Atlanta (bottom left) and destroying anything of military value, such as railroad tracks (bottom right), he proceeded to march to the seaside town of Savannah (top right), presenting it to President Lincoln as a "Christmas present" on December 21 (next page).

Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman's letter to the leaders of Atlanta, responding to their request that he rescind his orders to evacuate and burn the city:

Gentlemen: I have your letter of the 11th, in the nature of a petition to revoke my orders removing all the inhabitants from Atlanta. I have read it carefully, and give full credit to your statements of distress that will be occasioned, and yet shall not revoke my orders, because they were not designed to meet the humanities of the cause, but to prepare for the future struggles in which millions of good people outside of Atlanta have a deep interest. We must have peace, not only at Atlanta, but in all America. To secure this, we must stop the war that now desolates our once happy and favored country. To stop war, we must defeat the rebel armies which are arrayed against the laws and Constitution that all must respect and obey. To defeat those armies, we must prepare the way to reach them in their recesses, provided with the arms and instruments which enable us to accomplish our purpose. Now, I know the vindictive nature of our enemy, that we may have many years of military operations from this quarter; and, therefore, deem it wise and prudent to prepare in time. The use of Atlanta for warlike purposes is inconsistent with its character as a home for families. There will be no manufacturers, commerce, or agriculture here, for the maintenance of families, and sooner or later want will compel the inhabitants to go. Why not go now, when all the arrangements are completed for the transfer; instead of waiting till the plunging shot of contending armies will renew the scenes of the past month? Of course, I do not apprehend any such things at this moment, but you do not suppose this army will be here until the war is over. I cannot discuss this subject with you fairly, because I cannot impart to you what we propose to do, but I assert that our military plans make it necessary for the inhabitants to go away, and I can only renew my offer of services to make their exodus in any direction as easy and comfortable as possible.

You cannot qualify war in harsher terms than I will. War is cruelty, and you cannot refine it; and those who brought war into our country deserve all the curses and maledictions a people can pour out. I know I had no hand in making this war; and I know I will make more sacrifices to-day than any of you to secure peace. But you cannot have peace and a division of our country. If the United States submits to a division now, it will not stop, but will go on until we reap the fate of Mexico, which is eternal war. The United States does and must assert its authority, wherever it once had power; for, if it relaxes one bit to pressure, it is gone, and I believe that such is the national feeling. This feeling assumes various shapes, but always comes back to that of Union. Once admit the Union, once more acknowledge the authority of the national Government, and, instead of devoting your houses and streets and roads to the dread uses of war, I and this army become at once your protectors and supporters, shielding you from danger; let it come from what quarter it may. I know that a few individuals cannot

resist a torrent of error and passion, such as swept the South into rebellion, but you can point out, so that we may know those who desire a government, and those who insist on war and its desolation.

You might as well appeal against the thunder-storm as against these terrible hardships of war. They are inevitable, and the only way the people of Atlanta can hope once more to live in peace and quiet at home, is to stop the war; which can only be done by admitting that it began in error and is perpetuated in pride.

We don't want your Negroes, or your horses, or your lands, or any thing you have, but we do want and will have a just obedience to the laws of the United States. That we will have, and if it involved the destruction of your improvements, we cannot help it.

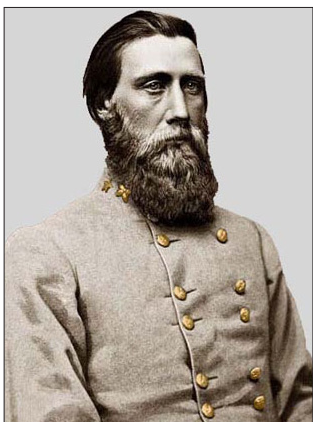
You have heretofore read public sentiment in your newspapers, that live by falsehood and excitement; and the quicker you seek for truth in other quarters, the better. I repeat then that, but the original compact of government, the United States had certain rights in Georgia, which have never been relinquished and never will be; that the South began the war by seizing forts, arsenals, mints, custom-houses, etc., etc., long before Mr. Lincoln was installed, and before the South had one jot or tittle of provocation. I myself have seen in Missouri, Kentucky, Tennessee, and Mississippi, hundreds and thousands of women and children fleeing from your armies and desperadoes, hungry and with bleeding feet. In Memphis, Vicksburg, and Mississippi, we fed thousands and thousands of the families of rebel soldiers left on our hands, and whom we could not see starve. Now that war comes to you, you feel very different. You deprecate its horrors, but did not feel them when you sent car-loads of soldiers and ammunition, and moulded shells and shot, to carry war into Kentucky and Tennessee, to desolate the homes of hundreds and thousands of good people who only asked to live in peace at their old homes, and under the Government of their inheritance. But these comparisons are idle. I want peace, and believe it can only be reached through union and war; and I will ever conduct war with a view to perfect an early success.

But, my dear sirs, when peace does come, you may call on me for any thing. Then will I share with you the last cracker; and watch with you to shield your homes and families against danger from every quarter.

Now you must go, and take with you the old and feeble, feed and nurse them, and build for them, in more quiet places, proper habitations to shield them against the weather until the mad passions of men cool down, and allow the Union and peace once more to settle over your old homes in Atlanta.

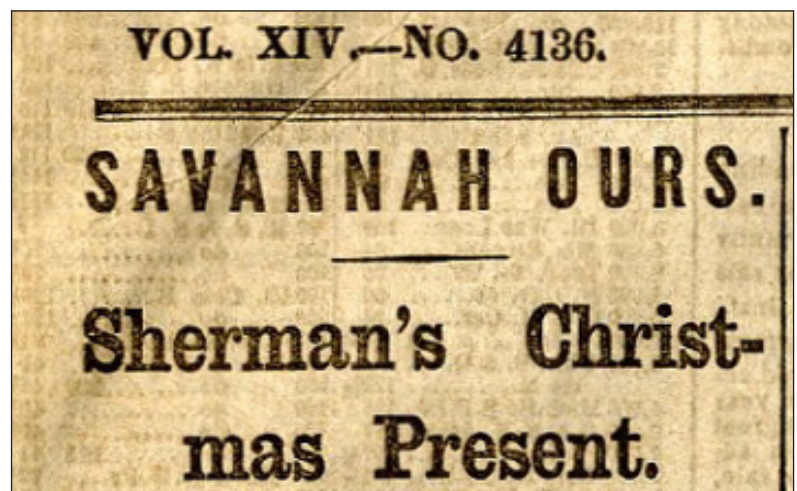
Yours in haste,

W.T. Sherman,
Major-General commanding

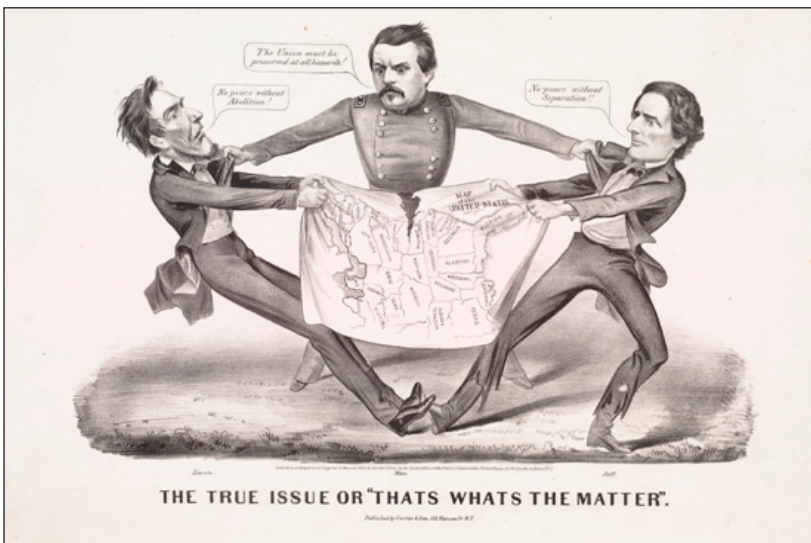
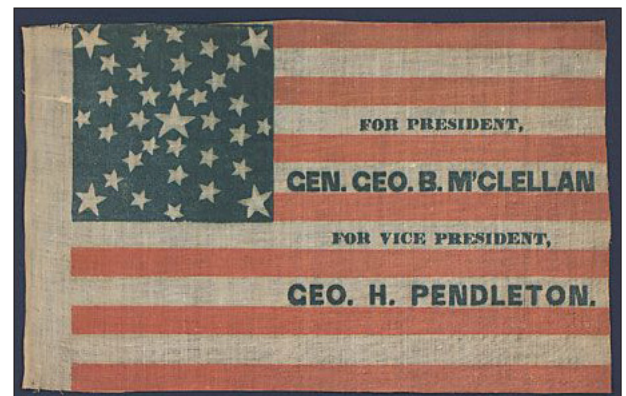


We will fight you to the death. Better die a thousand deaths than submit to live under you or your Government and your negro allies.

**- Confederate Lt. Gen.
John Bell Hood**



The Election of 1864



Clement Vallandigham (seated at center; top left) was one of President Lincoln's most powerful enemies during the Civil War; leader of the "Copperhead" Democrats that demanded an immediate end to the conflict. He had largely been discredited by the latter half of 1864, however; and so the Democrats chose former General-in-Chief George McClellan as their candidate. Editorialists often lampooned his self-important attitude, as in this cartoon (bottom left) that shows him "saving" the country from Abraham Lincoln and Jefferson Davis. Part of Lincoln's re-election pitch that year centered on his status as a family man; he posed for the famous photograph with his son Tad in August of 1864 (top right). Nineteenth century elections often included customized American flags with candidates' names (bottom right).

Closing of President Lincoln's Second Inaugural Address:

The Almighty has his own purposes. "Voe unto the world because of offenses! for it must needs be that offenses come; but woe to that man by whom the offense cometh." If we shall suppose that American slavery is one of those offenses which, in the providence of God, must needs come, but which, having continued through his appointed time, he now wills to remove, and that he gives to both North and South this terrible war; as the woe due to those by whom the offense came, shall we discern therein any departure from those divine attributes which the believers in a living God always ascribe to him? Fondly do we hope—fervently do we pray—that this mighty scourge of war may speedily pass away. Yet, if God wills that it continue until all the wealth piled by the bondman's two hundred and fifty years of unrequited toil shall be sunk, and until every drop of blood drawn with the lash shall be paid by another drawn with the sword, as was said three thousand years ago, so still it must be said, "The judgments of the Lord are true and righteous altogether."

With malice toward none; with charity for all; with firmness in the right, as God gives us to see the right, let us strive on to finish the work we are in; to bind up the nation's wounds; to care for him who shall have borne the battle, and for his widow, and his orphan—to do all which may achieve and cherish a just and lasting peace among ourselves, and with all nations.

The Road to Appomattox: April 2-9, 1865

Timeline

April 3:

Confederate forces move west on multiple routes.

April 4-5:

The bulk of Confederate forces concentrate at Amelia Court House

April 5:

Union forces arrive near Jettersville and block Confederate movement south along the railroad

April 5, evening:

Union Maj. Gen. Edward Ord's Army of the James arrives at Burke, Va.

April 6:

At the Battle of Sayler's Creek, the Confederate rear guard is cut off and 6,000 men are captured

April 7:

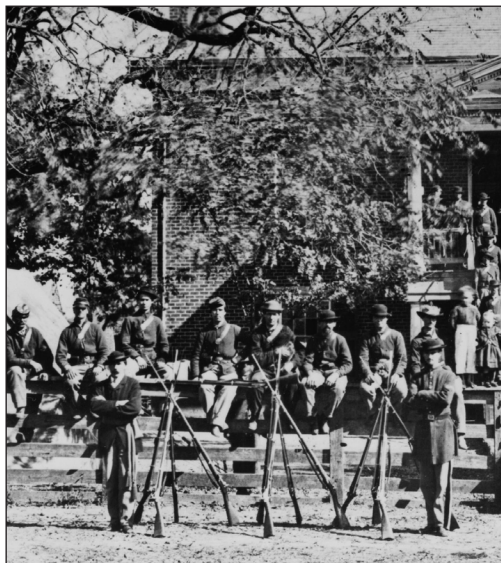
At the battle of Farmville, Confederates fend off Union troops long enough to escape to Appomattox

April 8:

Gen. Robert E. Lee's army concentrates at Appomattox Court House

April 9:

With no means of escape, Lee surrenders to Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant. Though there are still Confederate armies in the field, the Civil War is effectively over



Robert E. Lee (top left) was photographed at his residence in Richmond, several days after the surrender; wearing the uniform in which he had met General Grant. Lee disliked being photographed, and the scarcity of images of him resulted in his being portrayed throughout the Civil War with black hair and a mustache, but no beard, as he had appeared during his days as an instructor at West Point.

The surrender took place at the McLean house in Appomattox Court House (top right); it was quickly stripped of nearly all furnishings and decorations by souvenir hunters.

Union soldiers waited patiently at Appomattox for the good news that they suspected was coming (left). Grant ordered them to remain silent throughout and after the proceedings, so as to avoid any bitterness on the part of the defeated Confederates.

Ulysses S. Grant's recollection of the surrender of Robert E. Lee:

I had known General Lee in the old army, and had served with him in the Mexican War; but did not suppose, owing to the difference in our age and rank, that he would remember me; while I would more naturally remember him distinctly, because he was the chief of staff of General Scott in the Mexican War.

When I had left camp that morning I had not expected so soon the result that was then taking place, and consequently was in rough garb. I was without a sword, as I usually was when on horseback on the field, and wore a soldier's blouse for a coat, with the shoulder straps of my rank to indicate to the army who I was. When I went into the house I found General Lee. We greeted each other; and after shaking hands took our seats. I had my staff with me, a good portion of whom were in the room during the whole of the interview.

What General Lee's feelings were I do not know. As he was a man of much dignity, with an impassable face, it was impossible to say whether he felt inwardly glad that the end had finally come, or felt sad over the result, and was too manly to show it. Whatever his feelings, they were entirely concealed from my observation; but my own feelings, which had been quite jubilant on the receipt of his letter [proposing negotiations], were sad and depressed. I felt like anything rather than rejoicing at the downfall of a foe who had fought so long and valiantly, and had suffered so much for a cause, though that cause was, I believe, one of the worst for which a people ever fought, and one for which there was the least excuse. I do not question, however, the sincerity of the great mass of those who were opposed to us.

General Lee was dressed in a full uniform which was entirely new, and was wearing a sword of considerable value, very likely the sword which had been presented by the State of Virginia; at all events, it was an entirely different sword from the one that would ordinarily be worn in the field. In my rough traveling suit, the uniform of a private with the straps of a lieutenant-general, I must have contrasted very strangely with a man so handsomely dressed, six feet high and of faultless form. But this was not a matter that I thought of until afterwards.

